3.1 War in the Southern Colonies

When you're losing a game, sometimes it helps to change your strategy. That's what the British decided to do. But would moving the war south help or hurt them?

MAIN IDEA At first, southern battles went badly for the Continental Army, but the Patriots soon found ways to torment the British.

EARLY LOSSES

The British deployed a new strategy in the Southern Colonies in 1778. They counted on Loyalist and African-American support in Georgia, the Carolinas, and Virginia. They used the islands of the British West Indies to gather and transport supplies and recruits for the British and their allies.

But French-held territory in the Caribbean provided aid to the Continental Army's southern campaign. The French Colonial Army recruited many soldiers for the American cause from its islands, such as Saint-Domingue (san dom-ANG), or present-day Haiti. Their numbers included enslaved men willing to fight against the British.

Enslaved African Americans in the Southern Colonies were also recruited to fight for the British. General Henry Clinton offered freedom to enslaved men who joined the British Army. As a result, African-American support for the British grew in the Southern Colonies.



CRITICAL VIEWING In 1780, Francis Marion lured a British force 26 miles into the heart of a South Carolina swamp. Will Anderson illustrated this episode in a mural he painted in 2001. Why do you think the British (on horseback) might have had a difficult time fighting on the Swamp Fox's terms?

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In 1778, Clinton sent thousands of troops to Georgia. There they captured Savannah and Augusta, followed by Charleston, South Carolina. In an effort to combat the British onslaught, in July 1780, American general Horatio Gates arrived to build a new southern army. But Gates failed to prepare these troops properly for battle. **Lord Cornwallis**, the British commander, had learned of Gates's movements and attacked the Americans at Camden, South Carolina. The British scored an overwhelming victory that spelled disaster for the Continental Army and disgrace for Gates.

THE SWAMP FOX

While the Continental Army suffered major losses in the South, nontraditional military units strengthened the American cause. **Guerrilla** units, or independent military groups that used methods such as sneak attacks, thrived in the rural wetlands of the American Southeast. South Carolina officer **Francis Marion** and his small group of guerrillas harassed British troops through the swamps of Georgia and the Carolinas. Because he was so clever and good at dodging the British, Marion soon earned the nickname "the Swamp Fox."

Marion had once been a regular soldier fighting for the Patriots. But General Gates dismissed him before the disastrous Battle of Camden to focus on defending other territories. Marion soon discovered his genius for guerrilla warfare—conducting surprise attacks on the British, gathering intelligence about the enemy, and winning the loyalty of local people. Despite the many early American defeats in the Southern Colonies, guerilla leaders such as Marion caused enough trouble for the British to keep the United States competitive—and, eventually, on the path to victory.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What early wins did the British score in the Southern Colonies?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What role did France play in the war in the Southern Colonies?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What characteristics of a fox did Francis Marion demonstrate as a guerrilla leader?



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